

A photograph of a man and a woman in a doorway. The woman is wearing a white off-the-shoulder crop top and white denim shorts, leaning back against the man. The man is wearing a black t-shirt and jeans, smiling and holding her. In the foreground, a man with glasses is looking down at a laptop screen, which is out of focus.

The Man Who Slept Directly Over Them
Taken Erotica

JJ Vale

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The walls and floors were thin enough to hear footsteps. That was the first thing Mason noticed when they moved in to their new apartment. The upstairs tenant, whoever he was, ran every morning, showered with music on, and and watched a lot of football. Mason didn't complain. Noise was part of the charm of century-old apartment buildings, he told Lauren. Real hardwood floors, old doors, windows with iron frames. Lauren smiled and unpacked the mugs.

They kept a soft and quiet life. Mason worked from home, always in sweatpants and a hoodie, fingers constantly moving across his laptop keys, sometimes muttering dialogue to himself. Lauren worked part-time at a boutique two blocks over, liked walking back with a smoothie in hand, her phone in the other, still in her work flats and tan skirt, her hair bouncing. She never spoke until she'd kissed his cheek and dropped her bag on the counter. They had a rhythm and it was a simple one they both settle into and liked well enough.

But he came into it like bad weather. One morning Lauren passed him on the stairs, then again, the next morning, stepping aside to let his large frame pass. She didn't remember seeing him before. He was tall, wide-shouldered, darker-skinned, and always seemed mid-laugh, even without smiling.

Something about him fascinated her. She liked to think she was worldly and cosmopolitan, but she'd never known someone like him, not up close.

The first time she met his eyes, she looked away before hers fully widening. The second time, she returned his disarming smile. She told Mason there was a new guy upstairs. Mason asked if he was loud. Lauren shrugged. "He's just around."

"He watches football I bet."

"Probably. Looks the type, for sure."

She told herself she wasn't thinking about him when she wore her loose white tank with the thin straps and the high-cut jean shorts. It was hot out, after all. Mason was upstairs typing. She passed the man in the entry again,

said hi like she always did, having learned his typical time for coming home. He turned from the mailbox, lifted his brows, and held the door for her. She stepped through and felt her shoulder brush his chest. She looked up, said, “Thanks” with a voice that failed, and didn’t say anything else. But she smiled too long before walking on.

The next time, he spoke this time. His voice was lower than she expected, not booming but firm, and it made her pause at the base of the stairs before answering. Something about the way he looked down at her from above, the angle of it, the heat that seemed to rise off him, she answered slower than she would, her hand on the rail behind her. He asked if she lived downstairs, if her boyfriend was the guy always home on his laptop. She nodded and told him Mason was a writer. He laughed. “I figured. And you?”

“I work nearby,” she said, holding her cards close. She asked his name.

“Caleb,” he said.

When she gave him hers, “Lauren,” he repeated it, not correcting or teasing it, just saying it like he was already knew he’d be using it later. She smiled again and looked down as she stepped past him. He moved aside but far enough. She could feel him still facing her as she climbed the stairs away from him.

In the apartment, Mason was reading what he’d just written, head down, tapping his fingers at the screen like checking it for a pulse. Lauren didn’t speak, so as not to disturb him, and leaned at the sink a moment before heading to the bedroom to change.

Their bedroom window faced the alley. Light came in sideways, bending around the buildings across the lot. Lauren closed the door halfway, kicked off her shoes, and pulled the tank over her head with one arm crossed behind her back. She reached for her shorts, paused, then pushed them down and stepped out, leaving them folded near the dresser. The door creaked. She listened a second, then turned away and changed her underwear, this time into a thinner pair, black and low. Lace. She pulled on a long shirt that barely covered them and padded barefoot to the kitchen.

Mason was still clicking madly away. She slid into the chair beside him, crossed one leg over the other, and watched the screen. He was writing dialogue, something about a dinner scene. She tilted her head, rested her chin on her fist. “That one’s good,” she said after reading a line. He smiled without looking.

She went quiet again and let him work.

Later that night, they watched a show curled together on the couch. She tucked herself into him, and he kissed her forehead when the lights dimmed, rubbing her arm absently while watching the action flick. Lauren's mind wandered, though she control exactly where to.

She had felt the heat of Caleb's body through that brief brush on the stairs, the difference in posture, in space. His size was notable. Her breath had quickened, but only for a moment. It was nothing, really. He had an athletic physique, was all, like he looked after himself, worked out, ate well. Probably cooked well, too, as he had a French accent. She chuckled to herself.

"I bet it's soccer, not football you're hearing," she said to Mason, a wide grin for solving the mystery.

"Huh?"

"Upstairs, when you hear his games. He has an accent."

"You talked to the guy?"

"No," she said, putting her attention back on the show.

The next afternoon, Mason had a Zoom meeting with his editor. She didn't want to be in the background, so she took her smoothie and stepped out onto the common porch. The stairs creaked above. She didn't look until the second footfall, then casually glanced over her shoulder. Caleb was coming down in workout clothes, a towel slung around his neck. His shirt clung to his chest, damp at the chest, and his eyes flicked down to her legs before returning to her face.

"You always drink those ugly green things?" he asked, nodding at her cup, big grin spreading up his face.

"Sometimes," she said. "Depends how bad I feel about myself that day." She shrugged and chuckled at her own joke.

He grinned. "Today must be rough then."

It wasn't French exactly, not Paris French.

She laughed too loud and too fast, then touched her forehead like she was brushing something off. "Guess it was."

He stepped past her and paused at the base of the stairs. "I was going to do a second run later. If I don't melt."

"You always run twice a day?"

"Sometimes I do. It always depends on how bad I feel about myself." He laughed a rich, deep laugh, and saluted her before heading out up the alley.

She felt herself blush, felt her lips parting, but she didn't say anything back. He gave a slight nod, turned, and jogged down the alley, his towel shifting against his back with each step.

She waited until he was at the street before she exhaled. Her thighs pressed together, not out of modesty, but something else, some sort of unresolved energy, it felt like, like an itch behind the skin.

The door behind her creaked. Mason waved his phone, indicating to her his call was done. She smiled at him and went inside. But that evening she showered longer than usual, washing slow, turning the water to warmer settings, eyes closed, losing track of time.

Lauren didn't mind the stairs. They gave her time to reset, to check her phone, or think through whatever she didn't want to bring inside. But lately she lingered, at the base of the stairwell, by the locked mailbox row, or she hesitated just a second after getting the little newspaper she liked, hoping, not planning, of course, to hear the sound of his weight above, the creak of his footfall.

That Thursday, it happened. She had just bent to check the package box when she heard the door above open and close. Caleb descended, gym bag in one hand, earbuds hanging around his neck. He slowed his skip down the steps when he saw her, adjusting his grip, his gaze running a lower like it always did when he alighted upon her. She stood brushing her arm against the metal boxes, and gave him a soft neighborly smile.

"Don't tell me you're finally moving out," he said, glancing at the parcel tucked under her arm.

"Just new shoes," she said. "On sale, of course." She exaggerated the look of pride and laughed.

"Lucky you."

"Lucky me." She laughed, but her breath caught in her throat as he reached forward, brushed a loose thread from the hem of her top near her hip. His fingers didn't graze skin, but she felt them anyway. She didn't back away and she didn't lean in either. Her body locked up between options.

It wasn't anything to do with Mason, she told herself later. It didn't have anything to do with anything, she assured herself. A man can be interesting. A man can be disarming. She wasn't unhappy in any way with her relationship, and anyway, this wasn't about that.

He looked at her for a moment like someone not sure they recognize a half-famous person, then stepped past. She turned, watching him from

behind, her eyes low. How dare you not look over your shoulder at me, she thought, and when he suddenly did, she startled and spun away, caught.

Inside, she left the box on the kitchen table unopened. Mason was out getting groceries, and the apartment felt airless, still. She paced briefly, then walked to the mirror and pulled her top over her head, studying the loose thread he'd touched. Nothing was wrong with the shirt. She pulled on something tighter.

The next time they spoke, it was halfway in the stairwell. Mason had gone to a bookstore reading downtown, he was good about supporting colleagues like that. Lauren lingered by the railing just outside the door, pretending to scroll through her phone as though distracted by something enough to make her stop. Caleb came in from outside, shirt off this time, his skin slick with sweat and the faint outline of a key card in his waistband. He smiled when he saw her.

"You're always right there when I pass by," he said.

She hesitated, then smiled back. "Maybe you're the one who's always passing when I'm minding my own business out here."

He stopped a step below her giving her the advantage in height, but somehow it felt like the opposite. His eyes traveled up her bare legs, and slowly, too, like that was the only way he knew how to look at her now.

"What are you listening to?" she asked, nodding at the cord still dangling near his chest.

"Nothing right now," he said. "But you wanna hear something?"

She said yes without deciding to, and he handed her one bud. She took it, holding it to her ear without inserting it. A low beat played, sensual and deep. She nodded to it, but it was nothing she recognized, not even the genre. They stood like that, close but not touching, listening to his tunes.

Finally giving up the pretense of being sophisticated enough, she took out the bud and lifted her chin, gesturing to him. "What is it?"

"This," he said, taking the ear bud back and winding up the cord in his hand. "Is the best music of Ghana, Sarkodie."

"It's nice," she said, and she turned and nearly ran away up the stairs.

He watched her go and laughed that deep laugh of his again. "It's good, no?" he said to the blank wall.

When Mason got home, she was rearranging dishes in the cabinet and vacuuming the floor.

She started taking longer routes home from work, not because she was avoiding anything, but because she wasn't ready to walk straight in. Not ready to risk it again. Her keys stayed in her purse a little longer, her hand lingering on the gate or the railing, her pace slowing near the landing. She caught herself pausing at the same stair, the one where she first stood above him, where he'd looked up she'd not flinched.

What, she wondered, was she missing that she would do these things? Nothing, she insisted to herself. He was just a distraction, that man upstairs.

Saturday morning, she stepped out with the recycling. Her hair was still damp from the shower, tied up carelessly, no makeup, and wearing one of Mason's old t-shirts that hung just above her thighs. She didn't think anyone would see her, it was that early. She opened the bin lid with her foot and dropped the flattened boxes in, then turned and nearly walked straight into Caleb.

"Hey," he said, steadying the lid with one hand so it didn't slam shut.

She stepped back, swallowed her startle reaction. "Hey. Sorry, I wasn't looking." She screwed up at her face sideways. Looking for what?

He glanced down at her shirt, then back up to her eyes. "And I didn't mean to sneak up on you."

She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. "Just doing the glamorous chores," she laughed.

His eyes stayed on her face this time, softer now. "I like you like this."

She laughed again, not sure how to react. She crossed her arms, shifted her weight to her other hip, but she didn't retreat. "Like what?"

"Natural," he said. "No filters."

"I'm not a filter girl."

"You could be. But you're much better than that."

She looked down, bit her lip. The silence didn't feel awkward anymore, but it hummed. She reached for the doorknob, not turning it yet, just holding it.

"Have you got plans today? It's Saturday," he said.

"Mason's working. I might go out later."

"I'm heading out for a run. You want to come with me?"

She looked up sharply, then smiled, unsure. "I'm not a runner."

"You don't have to be. You just have to walk fast and pretend." He laughed.

She laughed too, but he tilted his head, waiting as though the offer was for real. She hesitated, then said, “Maybe another time, Caleb..”

He nodded, stepped back, and jogged down the front path. She watched until he turned the corner, then exhaled and stepped inside, her heartbeat louder than the closing door.

In the bathroom, she wiped under her eyes as though removing makeup she hadn’t worn. Her reflection looked unsettled. Not ashamed, but charged, like something was happening to her body from the outside in. She leaned forward bracing the counter, and stared until her breathing slowed.

That afternoon, she put on leggings and a light top, one with a plunging neckline she usually saved for dinners out. Mason noticed. “You going somewhere?”

“Just felt like not being such a slob today,” she laughed.

He nodded, got distracted by his screen, and she stepped out for a walk that had no destination. Just walk fast, he said, as if. She came back, past the street, then turned back, then up the front steps where she still saw no one. His door was open a crack at the top of the stairs and she didn’t look away fast enough.

It swung open just a little bit more as she passed on the hallway below. There was no creak, no call from inside, just a subtle movement like a breeze or a shadow. Lauren kept walking, but slower now, the hairs on her arms lifting as if touched by current. She didn’t glance back until she reached her door, and even then, she only saw the door still ajar, still quiet, as though waiting. Her breath drew tight in her chest until she made it through her door and back into their apartment.

That night, she was distracted. Mason suggested a movie, one of the old ones he loved, and she curled against him on the couch, her legs tucked under, but her attention drifted. When he leaned to kiss her, she kissed back but didn’t deepen it. She smiled and shifted, adjusted the blanket, and he returned to watching. But inside she was a storm.

The next morning, she stepped out early to catch the sun while it was still low. The front walkway was warm already, concrete drying in patches. She sat on the steps in gym shorts and a zip hoodie, coffee in one hand, legs stretched out across the bottom stair. Her hair was pulled high.

She didn’t expect him so early, but Caleb stepped out of the building barefoot, holding a jug of water and blinking in the morning light. He didn’t see her until he was halfway down the steps.

“Oh, didn’t mean to crash your morning,” he said, voice still rough from sleep.

She sipped. “You live here too.”

He sat on the railing, stretched one leg along the edge, the other hanging. His shirt rode up slightly. She didn’t look directly but knew the line of his waist was visible. He drank from the jug and handed it to her without asking. She took it, her lips brushing the rim, then passed it back without speaking.

“You good?” he asked, watching her.

She nodded, but a little too quickly. “Just up early.”

He didn’t press her on it. But he stayed there, quiet beside her, letting the silence fill the air between them like a different kind of heat. Her foot brushed his shin, lightly, accidentally, but neither of them moved. She stood finally, brushing off the back of her shorts. “I should go back in.”

He nodded, but as she passed him, his hand caught her wrist, not tightly, not urgently, but enough. She paused looking down at the fingers around her arm. He let go just as gently, and when she looked up, his eyes were already lowered, respectfully and unreadable.

“I’m not pushing,” he said. “I guess I wanted you to stay with me a little longer. I shouldn’t have done that.”

She didn’t answer. She turned and went inside, pulse tapping like a finger on glass. She closed the door softly, leaned her back into it, and stayed there a moment, her eyes closed.

He remained on the railing unmoving, sipping again from the water jug, eyes cast toward the street but unfocused, like watching something replay in his mind.

The next time was small and came without plan or warning, slipping in sideways like everything else. Lauren had gone out late to pick up a few things, milk, coffee, some kind of sparkling drink Mason liked chilled in the evenings. She came back with the grocery bag clutched against her chest, digging one hand into her purse for the keys, when the door opened. She didn’t have to look. The timing told her who it was.

“You’re out late,” Caleb said, standing barefoot again, a t-shirt loose over his frame, gym shorts hanging low on his hips. He held a laundry basket at his side.

Lauren kept her head lowered a second longer, then looked up with a smile. “Just grabbing some things.”

He nodded, stepped down two stairs, then paused. "Here," he said, holding out his hand. "That bag looks heavy."

"It's fine," she said, but didn't resist when he took it from her anyway, his fingers brushing hers for the second time. His hand stayed longer than necessary but not long enough to make her move.

He carried it to the door for her, holding it in one hand while his other braced the doorframe, his arm outstretched above her. She ducked down under his arm and unlocked it slowly, aware of how close he was behind her, how the night air cooled her legs, and the hallway smelled faintly of detergent from the basket he carried.

"Thanks," she said as the door clicked open. He handed the bag over but didn't step inside.

"You always look good," he said, low, not pressing, spoken like it was a simple truth delivered without needing a response.

She stood still, her grip tight on the bag. "You say that a lot."

"I mean it every time."

She nodded. "You should get your laundry done before it's midnight."

He smiled at that, his head dipping once. "Right," he said and he smiled and saluted.

She closed the door softly between them and leaned against it again, heart fluttering madly.

Later, when Mason was brushing his teeth and the bathroom fan was running, she pulled her phone out and stared at the screen. No messages and nothing from Caleb. But of course not, he hadn't asked for her number. But her body tingled anyway, like it was waiting for something from him. She set the phone down and slid beneath the sheets, Mason already half-asleep beside her.

Her dreams were vivid and disjointed: hands that weren't Mason's brushing her thigh, lips grazing the inside of her wrist, breath near her ear. She woke warm, flushed between the legs, and pressed her thighs together beneath the sheets without moving. She kept her eyes closed, pretending to still be asleep, even after Mason rolled away and got up to make coffee.

She stayed like that until she heard the front door below open, then close again. Only then did she reach under the covers and slide her hand between her legs, just for a minute, just to take the edge off.

Mason was great. They had a solid thing between them. There was no daylight for anything or anyone to get between them.

But Caleb kept popping up like that, and now invading her dreams, too.

She didn't go upstairs of course, not even when she thought how she might, how she could. Knock on his door. Disrupt him for a change the way he'd disrupted her so much lately. She didn't go up there even when Mason was stepped out for the day and she stayed home, the apartment quiet except for the ticking of the old pipes.

Instead, she waited. She sat at the kitchen table in a pale, ribbed tank with no bra and a pair of soft, frayed shorts she usually only wore to bed. She didn't clean, didn't read, just let time pass . . . and listened for footsteps on the stairs.

They came late in the afternoon.

She heard him descend, then stop. He paused on the landing. Then came a knock, soft, almost hesitant. Her heart skipped and she waited a beat, but then rose and opened the door, her fingers light on the handle, pretending she hadn't been standing just a few feet away.

Caleb leaned into the frame with a crooked smile. "Wasn't sure if you were in."

"I was. I am."

He glanced at her bare legs. "Hoped you might be."

She stepped back but didn't speak. He looked past her, eyes sweeping the room behind her. "He's out?"

She nodded. "Yeah." She tucked loose hair behind her ear.

He didn't move forward, he just waited.

Lauren didn't invite him in, either, but she left the door open and walked to the couch and sat with her legs tucked beneath her. He followed her, slowly, quietly, closing the door behind him with care, as though trying not to make it real too quickly.

"You always this quiet?" he asked, standing over her.

"No," she said. "Not always." She defied him with her eyes looking straight back at his.

He sat beside her but didn't lean in. His knee brushed hers. "You've been waiting for something."

Her eyes stayed on his. "I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to," he said shrugging.

He reached out now, slow enough to stop if she flinched. She didn't. His hand landed on her knee, fingers trailing upward, just grazing the inside of her thigh. Her breath caught, but her body didn't pull away. He moved his

hand higher. She shifted now, just slightly, and the edge of her shorts pulled tighter.

“Tell me to stop,” he said.

She didn’t.

He leaned closer, his mouth near her cheek, his breath slow, his hand paused just under the hem. She remained still, trembling slightly. Then her hand lifted and caught his wrist, not to push it away, but to hold it in place.

And that was enough.

He moved then, guiding her gently back until her spine met the cushions. His mouth brushed her collarbone, then up her neck, and her eyes fluttered. Her legs opened just a little, one knee falling sideways, allowing him between them. His palm slid over her hip, then under her shirt, feeling the heat of her bare stomach.

She whispered something he couldn’t hear. It might have been his name, might have just been air. He kissed her again, slower now, and she responded fully this time, her lips opening beneath his, her hips arching up into his thigh that pressed on her. Her fingers curled in his shirt, her breaths coming shallow and fast.

Then they both froze at the same time. A key turned in the door.

Lauren bolted upright, hair wild, eyes wide. Caleb was already up stepping toward the hall. She spun off the couch and ducked behind the kitchen counter as the door swung open.

Mason stepped inside with one arm full of books, the other reaching back to lock the door behind him. “You wouldn’t believe the deal I found,” he said, heading straight for the table without noticing anything out of place.

Lauren crouched behind the counter, heart hammering, her breathing tight and high in her chest. Caleb had vanished into the hallway in a flash, the bathroom door now silently cracked closed. She smoothed her shirt down, pulled the hem of her shorts lower, and rose slowly, pretending she’d just stepped in from the hallway.

Mason turned. “There you are.”

“Was in the bedroom,” she said, voice steady enough to pass.

“Check this out,” he said, flipping through a dog-eared hardback. “First edition. I think the guy didn’t know what he had.”

She stepped over, brushing her fingers through her hair, glancing toward the hall where Caleb remained hidden. Her pulse hadn’t settled. Mason kept flipping pages, oblivious.

“I’m gonna hop in the shower,” she said, backing away, forcing herself not to look toward the bathroom. “Walked around a bunch today. I’m gross.”

He waved a hand. “Go for it.”

She passed the bathroom on her way to the bedroom and gave the barest tap to the door as she did, not enough to be heard unless you were waiting for it. She undressed in her room in silence, tugging on a robe. She stood beside the door and waited, a towel from the linen closet over her arm.

A moment passed, and then Caleb slipped silently out, shoes in hand, eyes flicking once toward hers as he moved past her. She didn’t speak and neither did he. But he let his eyes draw down her robe and back up.

The front door clicked shut.

She stepped under the shower finally, letting the water pound her skin. Her thighs tingled from where his hand had traveled. Her lips still remembered his mouth. She braced both palms on the tile and exhaled hard. She hadn’t said no. She’d wanted it, God, she still did, but Mason was ten feet away with his headphones on and a book on his lap, completely unaware of the way her knees had nearly given out a moment earlier.

What was wrong with her? Why was she doing this? She rolled her forehead over the hard tile in the shower, and the water poured steaming over her back.

That night, Mason made dinner. They watched a film while eating on the couch. He laid his head in her lap and looked up at her like nothing was going on. She played with his hair, smiling when he said something funny, but her eyes kept drifting to the door, her skin still humming from earlier.

When Mason undressed and reached for her in bed, she kissed him softly, sweetly, then turned and curled into his chest, pretending to sleep. He didn’t press her. She felt his arm settle around her waist and her eyes stayed open long after his had closed.

Upstairs, Caleb lay awake, too, one arm behind his head, the other across his chest, remembering the heat of her skin under that thin shirt and the way she hadn’t pulled away.

They didn’t see each other for two days. Lauren stayed inside more than usual, half out of guilt, half out of confusion, and maybe a little out of fear too, fear of what she’d do the next time she saw him. Mason was home often, headphones on, writing stretches broken up by coffee runs and long

monologues about plot fixes she barely followed. She smiled and nodded, made food, kissed him goodbye when he stepped out.

She found herself checking the hallway before opening the door, waiting longer on the porch in case he passed. He didn't.

On the third day, she heard the weights. They thudded softly through the ceiling in a rhythm she recognized now. She stood under the noise, pretending to tidy a shelf, and counted the repetitions. Her body warmed just listening to him. When the sound stopped, she paced the kitchen for ten minutes before finally stepping out with a bag of trash, the excuse flimsy, but the need real.

She didn't expect him to be there, but he was. He stood outside the building, shirtless, his chest rising and falling, a sheen of sweat on his shoulders, a towel slung over his neck. He was leaning against the railing, water bottle in hand. When she stepped down, he looked up immediately.

Neither of them said anything at first.

Then: "You okay?" he asked, voice quiet.

She stopped a step above him. "I don't know actually."

He nodded once. "Me either." He looked down and grimaced, shook his head.

Her fingers clenched tighter around the trash bag. She looked down at it, then dropped it into the bin and brushed her hands on her thighs. She didn't move back to the door right away.

Caleb stepped forward, not closing the distance all the way, but enough that she had to look up to meet his eyes. "You don't have to say anything," he said. "I just wanted to see you again, but for real this time."

She hesitated and her breathing slowed. Her eyes stayed locked to his.

"Mason's gone tomorrow," she offered barely above a whisper. "All day."

Caleb didn't smile. He just nodded as if confirming something already decided.

"What time?" he asked.

"After noon. He's going to meet his editor downtown. Then some social thing. He doesn't get back till after midnight."

His eyes searched her face. "You want that?"

She paused, and then she nodded.

He stepped back, the space between them growing again, and she turned and walked inside. Her knees didn't feel steady until she reached the

bedroom. She sat on the edge of the bed, hands in her lap, staring at the hardwood floor like it would give her instructions.

That night she didn't sleep at all.

She showered twice, shaved everything, changed outfits three times, before settling on one and then changing again anyway. She watched Mason pack up his laptop and notes, kiss her on the forehead, and leave with a smile. She waited five minutes after the door shut before she moved.

She opened the door slowly, expecting him to already be there, waiting in the hall. But it was empty. She wore a robe only, and she drew the sash more tightly around her. The building was still and silent, that midafternoon hush where the world outside moved on without her. She closed the door again and leaned against it, her hands trembling. This is wrong, so wrong, she thought to herself. What was she doing? Why?

Then came the knock, three soft taps, spaced like a question.

She opened it without a word.

Caleb stepped inside, clean now, dressed in a dark shirt that hugged his chest and loose expensive jeans that sat low on his waist. He didn't reach for her, he just stood still, letting the moment settle, the air dense with things unsaid.

Lauren didn't speak either. She backed up slowly, her eyes locked on his. He followed, quiet, unhurried, until the door clicked shut behind him and they were alone.

She turned and walked to the bedroom.

He followed at the same steady pace, his footsteps barely audible on the old floor. When she reached the foot of the bed, she stopped, her back to him. She let the robe slip from her shoulders, the cotton whispering as it fell. Beneath it she wore nothing, no bra, no panties, just her skin, warm and flushed.

Caleb didn't make a sound.

She heard him exhale through his nose, soft and low, then felt his hands on her hips, broad, steady, and warm. He didn't pull her to him, he only held her like she might run, even though she wasn't going anywhere. Her breath stuttered as his mouth touched the back of her neck, then lower, slow kisses tracing the line of her spine. Her body softened under his touch, the tension she'd carried all morning melting with every press of his lips.

He turned her gently, not forcing, just guiding her, until she faced him. Her eyes were wide, locked on his. She raised one hand and touched his

chest, then let it slide down, catching the edge of his shirt. He lifted it over his head and dropped it on the floor.

He kissed her then, soft at first, slow enough to taste her, to let her respond. Her hands slid up his torso, then around his shoulders as she leaned into him, her bare chest pressing against his. The contact made her gasp into his mouth, and he swallowed the sound, deepening the kiss.

She broke away just enough to catch her breath, then dropped to her knees without speaking.

His eyes darkened. He stood still as she unfastened his jeans and pulled them down, then reached for the waistband of his briefs, watching his reaction the entire time. He didn't stop her and he didn't move. He just watched, his hands hanging loosely at his sides.

She slid them all the way down and reached for him, her fingers wrapping around him slowly, her lips parting. She looked up once more, her eyes wide and uncertain, glancing between his two eyes back and forth, but when he nodded, she leaned forward and took him into her mouth.

She started slow, shallow and teasing. He hissed through his teeth, one hand brushing her hair back as she found a rhythm, then sank deeper on him.

She grew bolder as she moved, her tongue tracing the underside of his length before she took him deeper still, her hands sliding up his thighs for balance. Her lips stayed soft, her jaw working gently, the pace slow but steady. She could feel his restraint in the way he gripped her hair, not pulling, but holding her, as if trying to anchor himself. His breathing thickened. He looked down at her, not speaking, his abs flexing with each pass of her mouth over him.

When she glanced up again, her eyes were glassy. Her cheeks hollowed around him, her body shifting forward for better leverage. He grunted softly, but when her motion grew too intense, he caught her chin and pulled her off with a wet popping sound, his chest rising hard.

She sat back on her heels, wiping the corner of her mouth with the back of her hand, flushed and breathing quickly. He pulled her up, both hands on her hips now, his forehead pressing against her chest.

"I want to taste you," he said.

She didn't answer but she leaned back onto her elbows, then let her spine sink into the bed, drawing her knees up and spreading her thighs slowly.

Her feet curled, her stomach fluttering under the tension of being fully exposed, she shut her eyes.

Caleb didn't rush. He moved down her body with long, slow kisses, one between her breasts, one lower across her stomach, then lower still.

When he finally pressed his mouth between her legs, she gasped. His tongue moved in slow, deliberate circles, lips warm against the most sensitive skin. Her thighs tensed, then relaxed, only to tighten again as he found the spot that made her whimper. He stayed there, patient and focused, his tongue flicking gently, then harder, then slow again. She threaded her fingers into his hair and arched her back, her head rolling to the side.

Her breathing quickened, legs trembling, her grip on him tightening when he sucked softly, holding her open with his hands. She moaned his name once, barely audibly, like she didn't mean to say it out loud.

It was the tension of the several past weeks, she thought to herself. It was the wrongness of it, as though that should make it better, faster. But while she recognized the sensations, she was wholly unprepared for their rapid escalation and relentless upward spiral.

She tapped at his head, clenched in her gut. What was he doing to her, on her? It was giving her no space, no time. Her hips danced under his face, her fingers searched for sheets to clench. Her head rolled side to side, her hair whipped over her face. Still he wasn't being fair.

She inhaled and held her breath and the rush of it, the way it uncoiled from deep inside her and lashed her with waves of warmth, it was like nothing else she'd ever experienced. She cried out loud, "I'm gong to come!" as though surprised, and no sooner had she said it, her spine curled back, her head rolled so far she was facing the wall behind her upside down, and her body spasmed as though electrocuted.

It was sudden and full, her whole body curling as a long, broken cry escaped her throat. He stayed with her through it, his mouth never leaving her until her legs twitched and she begged under her breath for a pause. He kissed the inside of her thigh and looked up at her, his lips glistening with her dew.

She looked down, dazed, her chest still heaving.

He stood and undressed fully now, his body lean and hard, the lines of his stomach tapering low. She reached for him before he even joined her on the bed, pulling him down over her greedily as she opened her legs again,

wrapping them around his waist. Her hands roamed his back, her hips rising instinctively. There was nothing stopping her.

“Are you sure?” he asked, voice thick.

She nodded, biting her lip, her eyes locked to his. “Don’t make me beg.”

He lined himself against her and pressed slowly, his weight braced on his forearms, his eyes never leaving hers. She held her breath, her nails biting into his shoulders as he entered her inch by inch. Her legs tightened around him, her thighs drawing him closer. She gasped when he sank all the way in, her back arching off the bed as her body stretched to take him.

Caleb stayed still at first, letting her adjust to him, his lips brushing her cheek, then her jaw. Her hands moved from his back to his sides, then down, tracing the curve of his hips as if memorizing the shape of him inside her. When he pulled back and pushed in again, slower this time, she moaned deep into his neck.

Every thrust came deeper. He moved with control, each roll of his hips solid, drawing out her breath in short, helpless gasps. Her legs moved higher, locking over his neck, pulling him in. She tilted her pelvis upward to meet him, grinding against him with growing urgency. The wet sound of their bodies meeting filled the room now, her thighs slick, her chest rising into his with every movement.

He picked up pace as her own confidence taking him grew, her moans no longer shy, her fingers digging into his arms as she whispered filthy things against his mouth. Her voice was unrecognizable, hoarse, raw, needy. She begged for it harder, for him to give her everything, to fuck her like they didn’t have a clock ticking somewhere outside that room.

He gave her exactly that. His hands slid beneath her back, lifting her into him. The angle deepened, and she cried out, biting his shoulder to muffle the sound. He thrust harder now, rougher, driving into her until the bed shifted under them. She met every stroke with abandon, her hips rolling, her arms clinging to him like she might float away if she let go.

When he slowed, it wasn’t to stop, it was to flip her. He pulled out, turned her gently onto her stomach, then lifted her hips from behind. She exhaled hard when he entered her again, deeper than before, the position forcing her open. Her cheek pressed to the sheets, her fists gripping the blanket. He held her by the hips and thrust into her steadily, watching the way her body responded to every push.

She was wild now, moaning into the sheet, meeting every stroke of his with hungry, unrestrained movement. She reached between her legs and touched herself, the pressure sending her spiraling. Caleb cursed under his breath, barely holding on. She was close again, he could feel it in the way her legs tensed, the way she shook, the way she gripped him inside, fluttered and contracted around him.

“I’m gonna come,” she gasped, voice ragged.

“Come for me,” he growled, thrusting harder, deeper.

She came hard, her whole body convulsing, her loud cries barely muffled into the sheets. He followed seconds later, groaning low as he emptied himself into her, his grip tightening before his whole frame softened against her back.

They fell over sideways and stayed joined like that for a long time, tangled, their bodies swamped and unmoving, the sound of their breathing the only thing in the room. Caleb eased out slowly, carefully, his hand tracing her spine as he pulled away. Lauren didn’t speak. She stayed on her stomach, eyes closed, cheek resting on the damp sheet, lips parted.

He leaned down and kissed the back of her shoulder before sitting back on the edge of the bed. His chest rose and fell as he looked over at her, the red marks from his hands still faint on her thighs.

She rolled onto her side eventually, blinking up at the ceiling, her legs drawn together loosely. Her voice was hoarse when she spoke. “That was . . .”

He turned slightly. “Yeah.”

She pulled the sheet up to her waist, not to cover herself but to anchor her hands. “I don’t know what I thought it would feel like.”

Caleb watched her a moment. “Do you regret it?”

Her eyes shifted to his. “No.” She grinned with a touch of nervousness.

He nodded. “That’s good.”

She sat up slowly, the ache in her thighs delicious and real. Her hair was a mess, her mouth swollen, her skin marked in places she hadn’t realized he’d touched. She looked at herself in the long mirror across from the bed and felt a strange sense of calm settle in. She didn’t feel broken or ashamed. She felt awakened. It wasn’t sex like that, she told herself. It was a work out, it was private, it was an exploration. “A provocation,” as she would have said back in college.

Caleb stood and pulled his clothes on in pieces, slowly, his body still humming with the weight of it. He came back to the bed, leaned down, and kissed her, softly this time, almost chaste.

“I’ll go before it gets weird,” he said.

“It’s already weird,” she murmured through a crooked grin.

He smiled and touched her cheek. “Then I’ll go before it gets worse.”

She didn’t walk him out. She stayed seated on the edge of the bed, watching the door close quietly behind him. When it latched, she let out a breath she didn’t know she was holding and dropped back onto the pillows.

The apartment stayed quiet for another hour. She cleaned up slowly, not erasing anything, but softening it. Sheets in the hamper, window cracked open, shower running hot. She dressed in the outfit she would’ve worn if nothing had happened. By the time Mason got home, the apartment smelled faintly of cleaner and fresh air, and little else.

He kissed her cheek and dropped his bag. “I got the files,” he said. “They pushed the deadline, though, so I’ve got some breathing room.”

“That’s good,” she said, smiling like normal.

He didn’t notice the extra flush in her cheeks or the faint mark at her collarbone. She kept her legs crossed when they sat for a snack, her tone light, her questions attentive. She even laughed at the right places in his telling her how it went.

Later that night, when he touched her in bed, she let him. She even pulled him closer, pulled him over her. But something in her felt different now, something still glowing, still warm. He hadn’t noticed, but she had.

When her boyfriend came inside her, the word suddenly came to her: “Dimensional,” she nearly said out loud. Like how poverty could be both from personal choices and external circumstances — it was dimensional, the same thing from two disparate sources. It was one word but meant two different things.

It was dimensional, what she was doing. Sex with Mason was one thing, sex with Caleb was a whole other thing, same word, but two completely different things.

That now settled, she slept instantly and more soundly than she had in days, now she had Caleb’s number, and he had hers, that man just above them even now.